

How Long Should Evidence Last: What Old Pattern Data Is Actually For

How long you keep evidence on a user isn't a fixed number: it depends on what the case file is actually for. On the difference between an open investigation and evidence from a closed case.

Evidence retention isn't about how long you're allowed to hold something against someone — it's about not losing the one thing that turns a scattered set of incidents into a visible pattern.

How long you keep evidence on a user isn't a fixed number. It depends on what the case file is actually for, and that's a question worth asking explicitly instead of defaulting to either extreme, keep everything forever or wipe it after every closed case.

An open, active investigation is the simple version. If a file is being built from a specific starting point, tracking an ongoing pattern, it stays live until that process actually concludes, because it hasn't been used for anything yet and the case is still current. That's not really a retention question. It's just an unfinished file.

The harder version is what happens to evidence after a case closes, after it's already been used for a warning or an action. The instinct might be that it's spent, used once, filed away, done. That's true for one purpose and not for another. The same evidence shouldn't be recycled to justify a second, separate action, that would be double-counting a single incident as though it happened twice. But if the same user surfaces again later, with a new pattern that looks like the old one, the closed case doesn't stay irrelevant. It becomes context. Not standalone proof of anything new, but a note that says this isn't the first time this shape of behavior has shown up, which is exactly the information you need to tell a coincidence from a pattern.

There's a specific reason this matters more than it might seem to. Behavior doesn't actually change on its own. It gets worn down, gradually, through consistent consequences, but the underlying tendency doesn't disappear just because someone stopped acting on it for a while. What can change, though, is the rules themselves. When a policy gets updated, a threshold shifts, a category gets redefined, behavior that used to trigger a clear response can suddenly fall into a gap the new rules don't quite cover. That's not the person changing. That's the framework changing around them, and it can hand back room to maneuver that consistent enforcement had closed off.

That's exactly why old pattern evidence doesn't get discarded just because the rules moved. It's not there to punish someone twice for the same thing. It's there so that if the same shape of behavior resurfaces, under whatever the current rules happen to be, there's a documented reason to look closer instead of treating it as a first offense under a new framework. Evidence retention, done properly, isn't about how long you're allowed to hold something against someone. It's about not losing the one thing that turns a scattered set of incidents into a visible pattern, especially once the rules have shifted enough that the pattern might otherwise look like it's starting over.

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